unnoticed. He would observe something about his children, something that he thought made them different from the others.

I was only six months old when Papaji started to teach me to sit. He would make me sit in the centre of the bed, and I would tumble forward and fall on one of the strategically placed cushions around. He would keep repeating this and I would keep falling. ‘You enjoy it, don’t you?’ he would say to me and I would apparently chuckle. Of course, I didn’t understand a word. But he was confused. Dada had started to balance himself when he was five months old. ‘Maybe she’s not ready yet,’ Maa said from the corner of the room as she fed Dada in her lap.

‘Maybe you’re right,’ he replied, gently placing me on the edge of the bed and reaching for a glass of water kept on the other side. As he drank from his glass, he noticed something that he would recount on multiple occasions when I had grown up. Twenty odd seconds had passed and I was still sitting straight on the edge of the bed. A minute passed and I was still sitting. Papaji’s eyes brightened and he exclaimed proudly, ‘Our daughter doesn’t belong to the comfort zone!’ He gleefully looked at my mother and said, ‘She likes being on the edge.’

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‘I think you should go wake your brother. He hasn’t come yet,’ the boy sitting in front of my seat said. It was the first and the last time he’d speak to me. The train halted at Mysore railway station and I unlocked my luggage from underneath my seat.

‘He’s not on this train,’ I told him and started to walk towards the exit while he sat there, confused. It was a pleasant afternoon and the road outside the railway station was still wet from the morning drizzle. The air was moist but not as warm as it used to be back home. As I boarded a taxi for the SSB centre, I couldn’t help but think about how my father had cherished every moment he had spent with me when I was a child. In those moments, he learnt things about me that he would later talk about, things that he believed made me different; it helped me in ways I had not